

1.1 Nature and Evolution of Social Science

1.1.1 Historical Context

The historical context of social science is rooted in the intellectual and cultural developments of human societies over centuries. Social science, as a formal discipline, emerged during the Enlightenment in the 18th century, but its origins can be traced back to ancient civilizations.

- **Ancient Civilizations**: Early forms of social inquiry can be seen in the works of ancient Greek philosophers like Plato and Aristotle, who explored concepts of justice, governance, and human behavior. Similarly, in ancient China, Confucius and other thinkers examined social harmony and ethics.

- **Middle Ages**: During the medieval period, social thought was heavily influenced by religious doctrines. The Catholic Church played a central role in shaping societal norms and values. Thinkers like St. Augustine and St. Thomas Aquinas integrated Christian theology with classical philosophy.

- **Renaissance**: The Renaissance period marked a revival of classical learning and a shift towards humanism. Thinkers like Machiavelli began to analyze political power and governance in a more secular context.

- **Enlightenment**: The Enlightenment was a pivotal period for the development of social science. Thinkers like John Locke, Jean-Jacques Rousseau, and Immanuel Kant emphasized reason, individualism, and skepticism of traditional authority. This era laid the groundwork for modern social sciences by promoting empirical observation and critical thinking.

- **19th Century**: The 19th century saw the formalization of social sciences as distinct academic disciplines. Sociology, anthropology, political science, and economics began to emerge as fields of study. Figures like Karl Marx, Max Weber, and Émile Durkheim contributed foundational theories that continue to influence social science today.

1.1.2 City of God to City of Man

The transition from the "City of God" to the "City of Man" symbolizes the shift from a theocentric (God-centered) worldview to an anthropocentric (human-centered) worldview. This transition is crucial in understanding the evolution of social thought.

- **City of God**: Coined by St. Augustine in his work "De Civitate Dei" (The City of God), this concept represents a spiritual and divine order. Augustine contrasted the City of God with the City of Man, emphasizing the eternal and heavenly nature of the former. In the medieval period, societal norms and institutions were deeply intertwined with religious beliefs and the Church's authority.

- **City of Man**: This concept represents the secular, human-centered world. The transition to the City of Man began during the Renaissance and gained momentum during the Enlightenment. It reflects a shift towards valuing human reason, empirical evidence, and individual rights over divine authority and religious dogma.

- **Key Developments**:

- **Renaissance Humanism**: Emphasized the potential and dignity of human beings. Thinkers like Petrarch and Erasmus promoted the study of classical texts and the importance of human experience.

- **Scientific Revolution**: Figures like Galileo, Newton, and Descartes challenged traditional religious views by promoting scientific inquiry and the use of reason to understand the natural world.

- **Enlightenment Thinkers**: Philosophers like Voltaire, Montesquieu, and Diderot advocated for secular governance, individual freedoms, and the separation of church and state. They critiqued theocratic rule and promoted the idea that human societies could be understood and improved through reason and science.

- **Impact on Social Science**: The shift from the City of God to the City of Man laid the foundation for the development of social sciences. It encouraged the study of human behavior, social structures, and institutions from a secular and empirical perspective. This

transition also led to the questioning of traditional authorities and the promotion of democratic ideals, human rights, and social justice.

In summary, the historical context of social science reveals a gradual evolution from religious and philosophical inquiries to systematic, empirical studies of human societies. The transition from the City of God to the City of Man marks a significant turning point in this evolution, highlighting the increasing importance of human reason and secular values in understanding and shaping the social world.